





Function of International Political Boundaries

- Identify claims to territory
- Control access to territory
 - Who/what is allowed to cross
- Contribute to national identity

International boundaries, or state borders, serve multiple functions:

They clarify a state's claims to territory, control access to that territory, and contribute to the national identity.

Defined

- Two political entities define the boundary between them
 - Treaty/agreement
- Location is decided based on:
 - Physical landmarks (river, mountains, etc.)
 - Geometric (coordinates)



A “Defined” boundary can be thought of as two states/political units agreeing to create the boundary between them. The location of the border (the imaginary line that represents the boundary) may be located along a naturally-occurring geographic feature or based on a coordinate system such as latitude and longitude.

For example, the Southern border of the US/northern border of Mexico were determined through a series of treaties and agreements, the most famous of which was the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, which set the border between the (then-new) US state of Texas and Mexico at the Rio Grande River. From the Rio Grande to the Pacific Ocean, the boundary is drawn geometrically. These boundaries were determined following the Mexican-American War in 1848 and had a significant influence on the culture of the region as the areas north of the border in the US were formerly part of Mexico (see “Diffusion of Language” notes in Unit 3 for an overview of this historical event).

Delimited

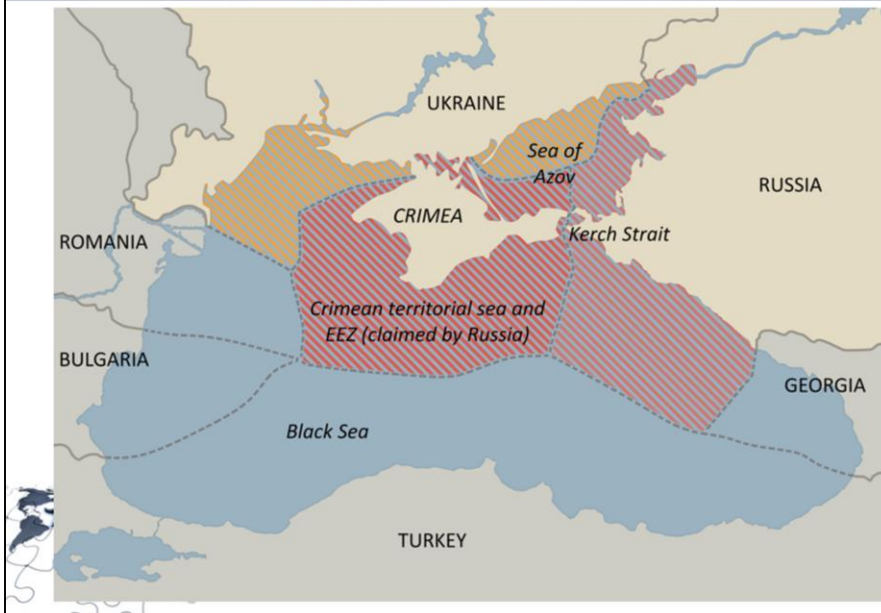
- Line drawn on the map
 - Role of cartography in politics



Boundaries are **defined** by political agreement (usually treaties). These boundaries are then **delimited** on a map (a line is drawn on the map) by cartographers to create a border.

Cartographers (map makers) are influential in global politics – if the delimitation of a boundary is drawn incorrectly, it can cause disputes. Likewise, if a cartographers indicates a territory is in dispute, it gives legitimacy to the conflicting claims.

Definitional Boundary Disputes



Real world example: In 2014, Russia claimed the Crimean peninsula, which is part of the Ukraine, which used to be a part of the Soviet Union (USSR). Russia claimed that because the area is mostly occupied by Russians, it is rightfully Russian territory. This would extend Russia's territorial waters and exclusive economic zone (EEZ – more on this later in these notes) into the Black Sea (which is also a navigable sea route, see map above).

The Chief Cartographer of the National Geographic Society, one of the largest and most respected non-governmental agencies in the world, changed the territory of the Crimean peninsula to "disputed". This gave Russia's claims over the territory some international legitimacy, though the US and European Union do not recognize Crimea as part of Russia.



A **demarcated boundary** is a boundary that has physically been marked onto the surface of the earth. It may be something as simple as a line painted on the ground or a road sign saying “welcome to ____” to something as physical as a heavily fortified fence or wall.

The images above all show demarcated boundaries. From top left going clockwise: the brick pattern shows the border between Belgium and The Netherlands, the border between India and Pakistan is heavily fortified, the border between the US and Canada is clearly marked with a “no touching zone” where trees have been cleared for over 5,000 miles of border, and border between the Republic of Ireland and Northern Ireland (UK) is marked with a road sign.

Borders can change over time – throughout history they may be more or less “open”.

Demarcation boundary disputes occur when the two countries do not agree on the placement of the physical marker denoting the boundary. If it is located in the wrong place, the side being shorted territory may claim the other side is encroaching on their territory.



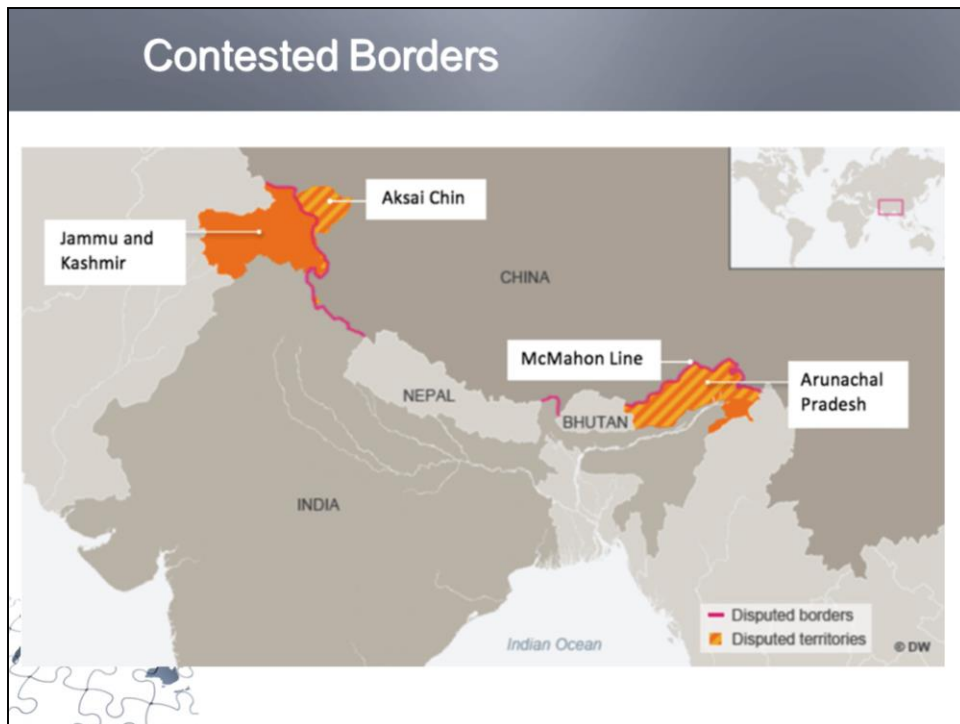
Are borders “open” or “closed”?

The answer to the above question is how a border is administered or operates. Border administration agreements determine who/what is allowed to cross the boundary and what documentation or fees need to be paid to do so.

*note here – airports are considered ports of entry, so technically they are a border zone even if they are located far from an international border, such as Dallas or Houston. A passport is an internationally acceptable form of identification that people use as documentation of their citizenship and is necessary to legally enter another country. Stamps are placed in the passport to mark the date of entry and mode of transportation (by air, car, sea, train, etc.) as well as the port of entry (sea port, airport, train station, or border crossing). Special permissions for a person to enter a country is called a “visa”, and are issued based on the purpose of the person’s visit – work visa, tourist visa, student visa, etc., and are placed in the person’s passport for travel purposes. If a country is not “recognized”, the passport issued by that country may not be considered valid in all countries. If your own country wants to prevent you from leaving the country, they may confiscate your passport.

Administration/operational border disputes occur when the two sides do not agree on how the border should be administered – one side says it should be more open or less documentation is needed to cross, while the other side says more documentation is needed and/or fees should be paid. One side may say that the border should be easily crossed, and the other says it should be closed (limited crossings). Visa applications typically require a fee, and some countries may require a visa for entry while others do not. This is a common dispute between the US and other countries – many countries allow American citizens to visit as a tourist without a special visa, but the citizens of those countries are required to obtain a visa to travel to the US and pay the fee associated with application and processing. As a result, some countries (such as Chile) charge American citizens a “reciprocity fee” that is equal to the amount their citizens have to pay to obtain a visa.

How open or closed a border is to people and movement of goods across international borders also depends on what international agreements are in place between those countries – for example, many states of Europe are part of an “open borders” zone called the Schengen Zone, which removes any barriers to crossing the borders. Once you are processed into one Schengen country you can go to any of the others. You do not even need a passport to cross – it is as easy to cross borders between Schengen countries as it is to cross the boundaries between US states. Not all European states are part of this agreement, though, which presents a challenge for non Schengen members of the European Union to enforce their boundaries because the EU has its own open borders policies. These conflicting agreements are an example of how operational border disputes occur. The map above shows the overlapping agreements – the blue represents states that are members of both the EU and Schengen. The green represents countries that are members of the EU, but not Schengen, and the purple represents states that are part of Schengen, but not the EU. The grey states are not members of either agreement.



Contested borders occur when the political entities involved do not agree on the definition, demarcation, or operations of the boundary between their respective territories. The map above shows the boundary disputes of India – The purple lines are disputed boundaries, and the striped areas are disputed territories. The Jammu and Kashmir territory (western side) is disputed between India and Pakistan. The Aksai Chin territory is disputed between India and China, as is the Arunachal Pradesh territory (eastern side).

Boundary disputes can be over land or over ocean territory.



Enforced boundaries

- Drawn and reinforced by international forces
 - Berlin Conference (Africa)
 - Demilitarized zones
 - 17th Parallel (now defunct, Vietnam)
 - 38th Parallel (Korea DMZ)

Sometimes the boundaries of states may be enforced by outside parties. Examples of these enforced boundaries include the colonization of Africa (Berlin Conference) and Demilitarized zones.

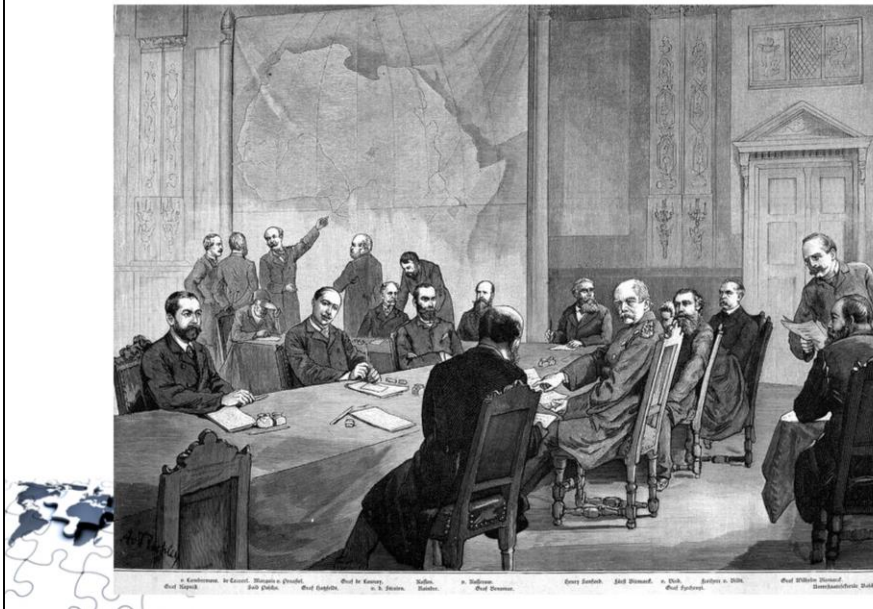


A **demilitarized zone**, DMZ or DZ is an area in which treaties or agreements between nations, military powers or contending groups forbid military installations, activities or personnel. A DMZ often lies along an established frontier boundary* or border between two or more military powers or alliances. Other states and international organizations such as the UN or NATO may take part in creating and enforcing these borders.

*a **frontier boundary** is a typically a wide swath of unpopulated area that acts as a buffer between two rival states. Geographically, these areas often have harsh physical landscapes, such as rugged mountains or deserts that are difficult for people to settle. As the satellite imagery shows above (top right), the Korean DMZ traverses rugged mountains at approximately 38°N.

While the most well-known DMZ today is in North Korea, it is not the only one. There are DMZs in Israel, Syria, between Russia and Turkey, and several other places. These borders are usually drawn as part of an armistice (cease-fire) agreement where both sides agree to stop fighting, but do not end the war – the Korean War has been in a cease-fire since the 1950s, but technically the war never ended and threatens to start up again periodically.

Berlin Conference



The Berlin Conference of 1884, was a meeting of European powers to regulate European colonization and trade in Africa during the New Imperialism period. It is sometimes referred to as the “Scramble for Africa”. For more information about the implications of this conference, see the colonialism and imperialism section of the “Political patterns and processes” notes and the “Superimposed boundaries” section of the “Political Power and Territoriality” notes, or your book (pages 218-219).



Impact of political boundaries

- Contribute to national identity
- Encourage or discourage interactions
- Allocation of resources
 - Disputes over access to/use of resources

Influence on national/regional identity

- Self-determination
- “We are _____”
 - Sense of belonging



National identity is a person's identity or sense of belonging to one state or to one nation. Having defined borders and a recognized territory helps give the nation a sense of cohesiveness and contributes to this identity. Other political acts that contribute to national identity include independence day celebrations, voting, anthems, flags, and pledges.

The photo above shows an Independence Day celebration in South Sudan. The Christian and indigenous religious groups of South Sudan fought for and won their independence from Sudan in 2011 after multiple civil wars over several decades. Hundreds of thousands of children were orphaned and walked to neighboring Kenya and other countries as refugees during the 1990s. These children became known as the “Lost Boys of Sudan” and several movies have been made about them, including the National Geographic documentary on those resettled in the US, “*God Grew Tired of Us*” and the feature film “*The Good Lie*”.

Encourage/Discourage interactions

- Border landscape
 - Inclusionary
 - exclusionary



Inclusionary borders encourage interaction between adjacent states. The border crossings on the left are inclusionary. There is little to no attempt to impede entrance into the state from the adjacent state.

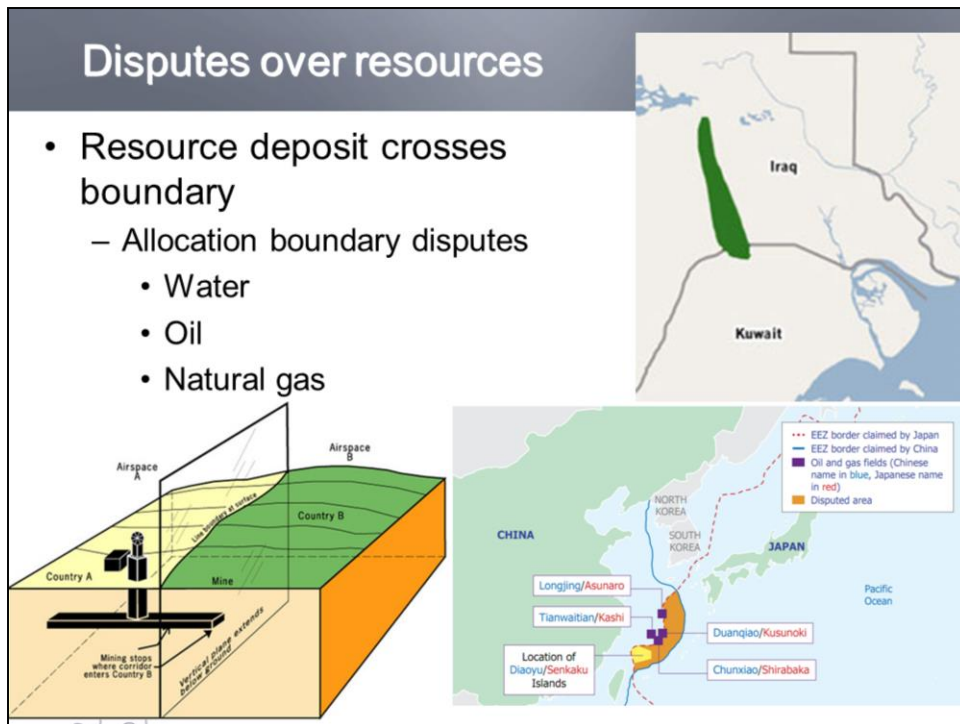
Compare the images on the left to the images on the right: these boundaries are exclusionary – they are meant to stop people from crossing them. The photo on the above right is a “peace wall” in Belfast constructed to separate Protestant and Catholics within the city. The lower right is the security wall built in Israel separating the Palestinians from the Israelis.

Walls, fences, or fortifications signify a closed border. Walls are not a new innovation – the Great Wall of China was constructed by several Chinese dynasties, and Hadrian’s Wall in the UK (marked the boundary between the Roman Empire and the unconquered Scottish people. These two examples date back thousands of years.

In the 20th and 21st Century, however, new walls have been constructed. There is a border fence between the US and many parts of Mexico (construction began in 1990 along the San Diego–Tijuana border) and has been added to by every presidential administration since, particularly in urban areas. This border

fence has been hotly contested by members of both political parties since 2006 (with passage of the Secure Fence Act of 2006), including opposition expressed by then-governor of Texas, Rick Perry, and leaders of Latin American countries. It is at the forefront of political debates today.

Other 20th/21st Century walls/fences include the Security Wall in Israel/West Bank, the Peace Walls in Northern Ireland, the DMZ between North and South Korea, among others.



Disputes over resources occur most often when the resource is a fluid – water, oil, or natural gas deposits. The plane of the border extends below the surface of the earth and above it into the airspace. Resource fields, therefore, may be located in multiple states. If the resource is fluid, harvesting activities on one side of the border will impact the availability of the resource on the other side of the border. Disputes occur if one state says the other is using too much of the resource.

The map on the above left shows the location of the Rumaila oil field, which is located mostly in Iraq but extends across the border into Kuwait. In August 1990, Iraq invaded Kuwait, which was condemned by the international community and seen as Iraqi aggression (under Saddam Hussein). In response, the UN Security Council implemented strict economic sanctions (punishment) against Iraq. A coalition of forces from the US, UK, Saudi Arabia, and Egypt, and 34 other states. This conflict became known as the Gulf War (Operation Desert Storm). Iraq countered by launching missiles at coalition targets in Saudi Arabia and against Israel. While the catalyst of this conflict was a territorial dispute, the roots of the conflict and the international response can be found in the Cold War – Iraq was historically a Soviet ally, and with the USSR on its deathbed (it officially disbanded in December 1991), international forces were concerned about increasing instability in the region. Additionally,

the US was concerned about Iraq's position on Israel/Palestinian politics, which at the time were very shaky, as well as Iraq's status as a state sponsor of terrorist organizations.

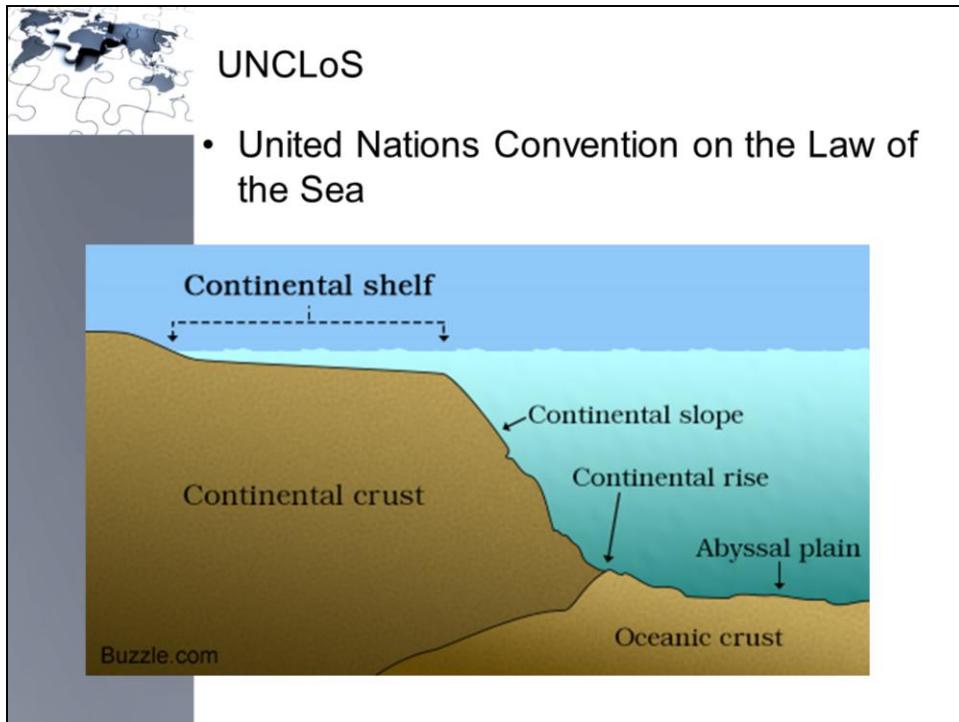
Mekong River Dispute

- Example of allocational boundary dispute
 - Diverting water/damming along a river



The Mekong River has its headwaters in the Himalayan Mountains in China. It traverses China, Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam. This river is a vital economic source to all these countries for fishing as well as irrigation. Dams are used to divert water for irrigation as well as to generate electricity. They are major infrastructure development projects that can greatly boost the economic and social development of a nation. The map on the right shows the location of all the dams currently existing, under construction, or planned along this river. The black bars are the dams that already exist. The gray bars (in China) are the dams currently under construction. The white bars are the dams that are being planned. Each dam reduces the amount of water that makes its way downstream. If all of these proposed dams are built, will any water be left by the time the river reaches Cambodia or Vietnam?

Other disputes over water, especially rivers, involve pollution (industrial or agricultural) as chemicals released upstream impact the water quality downstream.



The UNCLoS covers a wide range of ocean territorial issues, but it also provides the legal framework for the sustainable development of ocean waters. UNCLOS has thus emerged as an important part of the international legal system and also serves as an important instrument for the protection of the marine environment.

To understand the UNCLoS, a little basic geology background info is needed: When you think of the seven continents, you usually picture the shapes outlined on maps and globes. However, the true edge of a continent is not its coastline, but its continental shelf. Continental shelves continue underwater, and eventually, drop off into the deeper parts of the oceans. If a map were drawn with these shelves in mind, the continents would have vastly different shapes. Interestingly, much of the world's oil and natural gas resources are found underneath these shelves through offshore drilling.

Prior to WWII, the ocean waters were considered a “free for all” – if a country had the technology and means to access and exploit the resources of the ocean, they did it. Over-exploitation of the sea's resources was immensely felt towards the middle of the 20th century and many nations started feeling the need to ensure protection of their marine resources. This issue of global

politics was magnified during the cold war when the US and USSR were looking to build missile launch sites in the ocean bed. Beginning in 1945, the U.S. and other countries began to lay claim to their territorial waters – that is, the waters and seafloor (and resources located therein) along the continental shelf.

UNCLOS defined the rights of coastal countries (those with ocean access) in regards to these oceanic territorial claims.

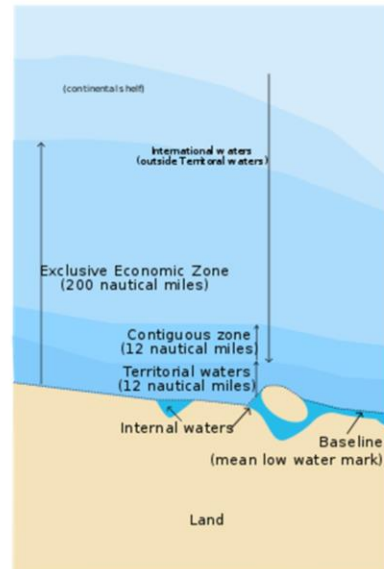
Definitions:

Coastal State: a country in which at least a portion of their border is an ocean, which provides access to the sea for trade and economic activity.

Landlocked state: a country completely surrounded by other countries and therefore has no coastline or ports to access the sea.

Territorial Seas

- 12 Mile zone extending beyond the coastline
 - Considered same as land territory
 - International recognition of this zone
- Contiguous Zone
 - Can extend another 12 miles beyond territorial sea
 - Countries have to negotiate their own disputes (not automatically recognized as sovereign territory)

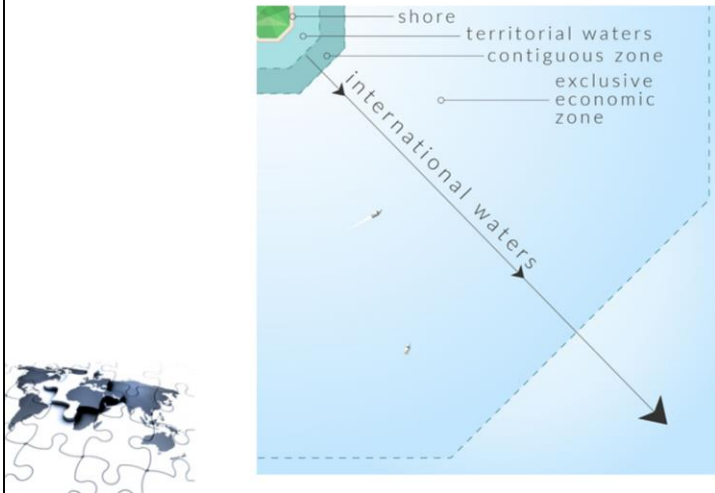


The territorial sea is regarded as the sovereign territory of the state, and extends 12 miles from the “baseline” (low water mark used to determine the location of where the water ends and the ocean begins) - although foreign ships (military and civilian) are allowed innocent passage through it, or transit passage for straits. this sovereignty also extends to the airspace over and seabed below. The boundary of the territorial seas is referred to as the “maritime delimitation” (or ocean border as drawn on a map). An invasion or encroachment by another country into this zone is considered the same as invasion or encroachment onto another state’s land.

Beyond the Territorial Sea is an area known as the “Contiguous Zone” (contiguous means “next to or adjoining”). Some states claim a contiguous zone of up to 12 miles beyond the Territorial Seas (up to 24 miles from their baseline). The difference between the Territorial Sea and the Contiguous Zone is that there is no automatic international agreement in place for protection of the contiguous zones – if there is conflict between two countries over the zone, it is up to them to negotiate their own agreements and compromise.

International Waters

- Ocean area outside of the territorial sea
 - **Beyond the 12 mile (max) territorial seas**



International Waters begins outside of each coastal state's 12 nautical mile territorial zone. These waters are also referred to as the "high seas".

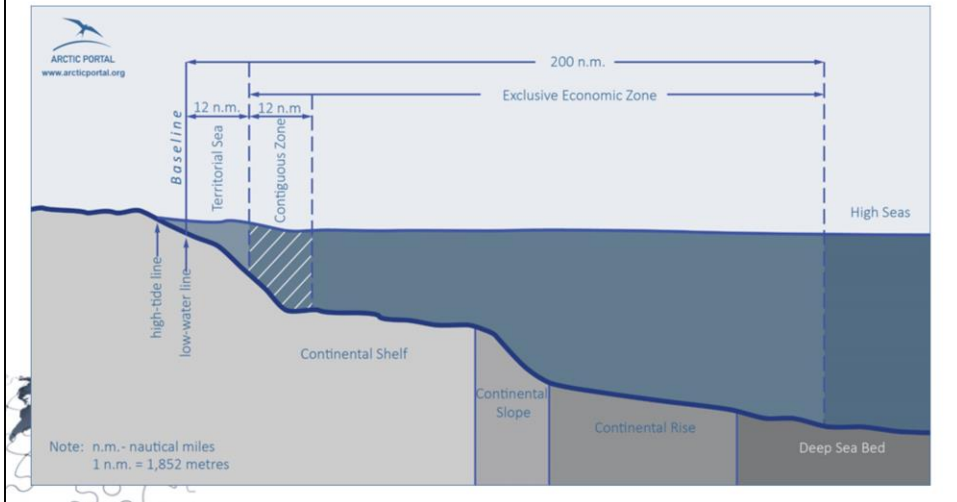
The high seas make up 50% of the surface area of the planet and cover over two thirds of the ocean.

Ships sailing on the high seas fall under the jurisdiction of the state in which the vessel is registered. Certain criminal activity, such as piracy, however, can be addressed by any country (usually the country of the threatened party) under the laws of universal jurisdiction*.

*jurisdiction means the official power to make legal decisions and judgments.

Exclusive Economic Zone

- 200 nautical miles beyond the state's baseline.

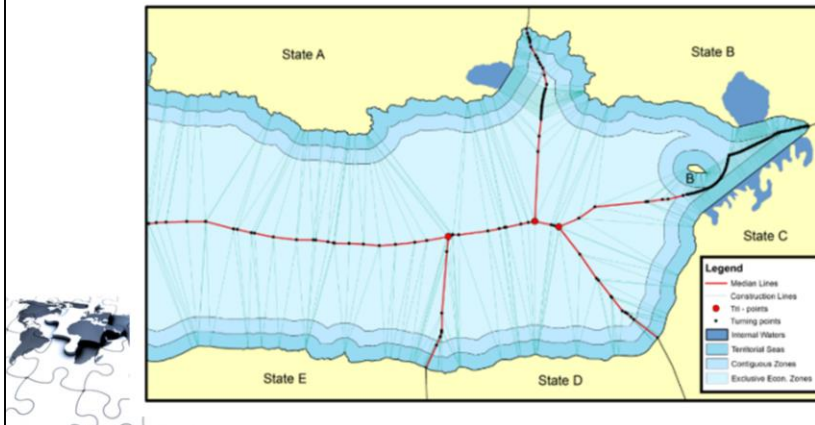


The Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) is an area of coastal water and seabed within a certain distance of a country's coastline, to which the country claims exclusive rights for fishing, drilling, and other economic activities.

The Law of the Sea provides for full economic rights to states for a 200-nautical mile zone by their shoreline. The sea and oceanic bed extending in this area is regarded to be Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) and the country has the sole claim to these waters and the sea bed contained within the 200 mile EEZ to use for their economic purposes (fishing, mineral extraction, etc.).

Median Line Principle

- Sets the boundary for territorial sea and EEZ if states are less than 400 nautical miles apart
 - **The middle point**

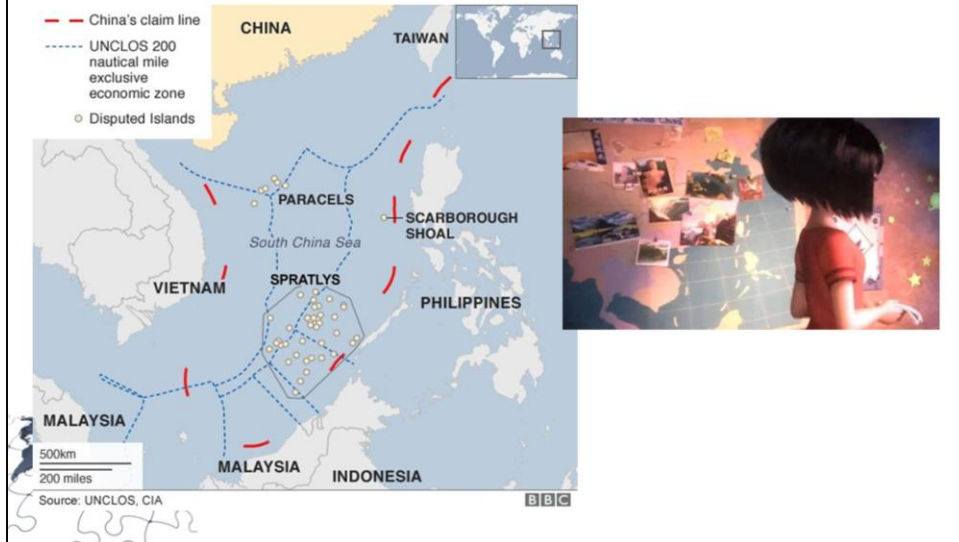


Median mean “middle” – Since the territorial waters extend 12 nautical miles off the baseline, and the EEZ extends 200 miles out, what happens if two coastal countries are within 24 miles or 400 nautical miles, respectively, the boundary of the territorial sea/EEZ is set at the middle point between the two states’ baselines.

The map above shows the hypothetical maritime claims of the fictional states above. The darkest blue areas shown are “inland” waters – waters located within the territory of the states. The medium-dark blue is the 12 mile limits of each state’s territorial sea, the medium-lighter blue is the contiguous zone, and the lightest blue are considered international waters. The states are less than 400 nautical miles apart, however, so the limits of each state’s EEZ cannot extend the allotted 200 nautical miles. Instead, it is set as the middle point of the distance between the states.

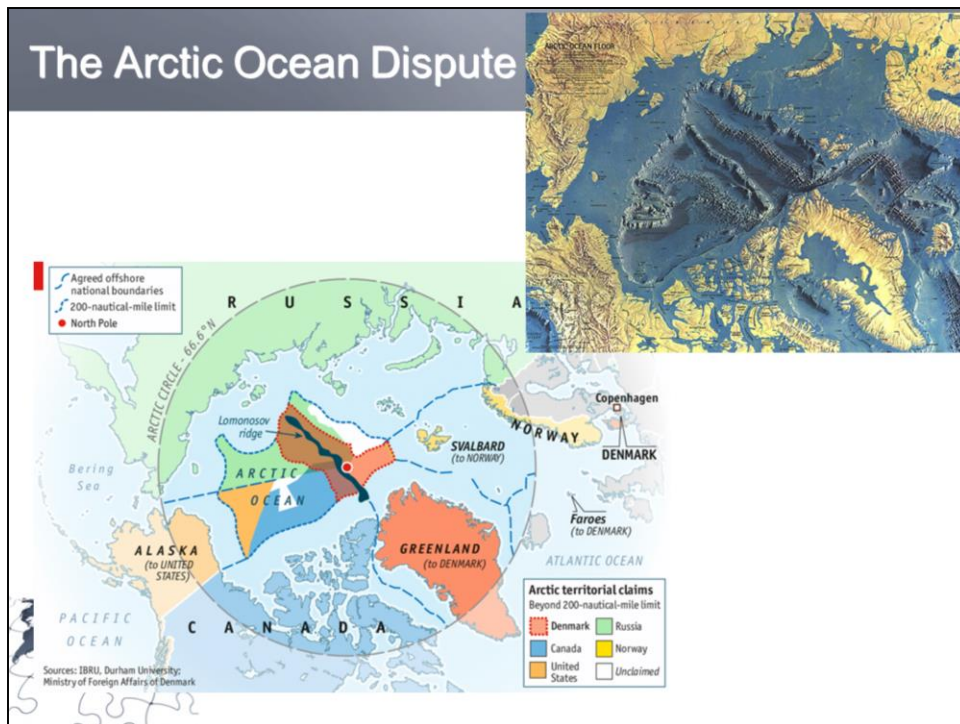
Conflict over Oceanic Territory

- South China Sea



The South China Sea disputes involve both island and maritime claims among several sovereign states within the region, namely Brunei, the People's Republic of China (PRC), the Republic of China (ROC/Taiwan), Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, and Vietnam. At the heart of the dispute are a series of small, mostly uninhabitable islands known as the Spratly Islands and the Paracels Islands. Claims of these islands would extend the territorial seas and exclusive economic zone of the state to which they belong. As of right now, China claims the Spratly and Paracels islands, and the other countries are contesting that claim because they, too, have a reason to claim them. You will learn more about this conflict in class when you complete the guided research on UNCLOS.

The map above on the left is the highly contested map known as the “Nine Dash Line” map. The nine red dashed lines on the map depict China’s claims to the sea, while the blue dotted lines show the extent of each country’s Exclusive Economic Zone based on UNCLOS. This dispute has spilled over into popular culture as the new movie *Abominable* (DreamWorks 2019) has been banned in many Southeast Asian countries due to it displaying this controversial map in the background of a scene (image above right).



When UNCLOS was adopted, the vast economic resources of the Arctic Ocean were essentially inaccessible due to the earth's ice cap. As the ice thins and recedes, though, the ocean waters and the resources of the sea floor are becoming more accessible. The countries with Arctic coastlines are hoping to exploit a clause in the UNCLOS agreement that extends the 200 mile EEZ based on claims that the continental shelves extend beyond the 200 mile zone and therefore extend the claims of each country.

The map above shows the claims of the different countries with Arctic claims – the red is Denmark (Greenland is an autonomous region of Denmark), blue is Canada, Orange is the US (Alaska), yellow is Norway, and green is Russia. The brown area in the middle of the map along the Lomonosov Ridge is brown because it is claimed by multiple countries and the colors overlap. Russia, Denmark, and Canada claim the ridge is an extension of their respective continental shelves, and therefore they have valid claims to extend their EEZ beyond the 200 mile limit. The map on the above right shows the topography of the floor of the Arctic Ocean.

There are vast oil reserves in the seabed of the Arctic Ocean.